

PHIL 480: A Conversion to Consciousness

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Heidegger sees poetry as a converter to consciousness. We lose consciousness during destitute times. A destitute time occurs when we lack the ability to see the nature of love, pain, and death. Poetry has the power to reveal such nature, which in turn, causes consciousness. Therefore, Heidegger views poetry, in his *What Are Poets For?*, as the converter to consciousness.

Heidegger comes to this conclusion when trying to understand the famous line: “what are poets for in a destitute time?” [1, pg.91] from Hölderlin’s *Bread and Wine*. He begins by first understanding what a destitute time is and when it began. He follows Hölderlin’s views in thinking that it began when the “‘united three’—Herakles, Dionysos, and Christ—have left the world” and now “the evening of the world’s age has been declining toward its night” [1, pg.91]. In other words, because these Gods have fled, we are left in a destitute time. Therefore, when the Gods became absent, we entered into a destitute time.

The consequence of this is that we are left suspended in the abyss. The abyss is the “complete absence of the ground” and we need a ground because “the ground is the soil in which to strike root and stand” [1, pg.92]. Thus, without a ground, we hang in the abyss. The only way to leave this abyss is if the Gods’ presence is revealed. Therefore, we need a way to reveal the God’s presence.

We can reveal God’s presence with a turning point. A turning point is the conversion from concealedness to the unconcealedness of God’s presence. This turning point only occurs “if the world turns about fundamentally—and that now means, unequivocally: if it turns from the abyss” [1, pg.92]. In other words, we turn away from the abyss when we turn around our core being. In order to do this, we first need a way to turn from the abyss.

Heidegger's solution to this is to find those who can reach into the abyss. Those who can reach into the abyss are those who can reveal God's presence. For instance, Heidegger believed "In the age of the world's night, the abyss of the world must be experienced and endured. But for this, it is necessary that there be those who can reach into the abyss" [1, pg.92]. In other words, because this destitution is necessary, there must also necessarily exist those who can save us. And, those who can save us are those who can reach into the abyss.

It is necessary to distinguish that those who can reach into the abyss are not old Gods nor new Gods because "How could there ever be for the god an abode fit for a god, if a divine radiance did not first shine in everything that is?" [1, pg.92]. Meaning that God cannot return unless the world welcomes him/her with a home to stay. Therefore, those who can reach into the abyss are mortal.

Mortals are the ones who can reach into the abyss because they are the ones who can observe the abyss. For instance, Heidegger believed that "He among mortals who must, sooner than other mortals and otherwise than they, reach into the abyss, comes to know the marks that the abyss remarks" [1, pg.93]. The mortals who can observe the abyss can also observe traces of symbols hidden in the abyss. The mortals capable of doing so are the poets.

The poets are the ones who can reach into the abyss because they are the ones who can trace the fugitive gods. For instance, "Poets are the mortals who, singing earnestly of the wine-god, sense the trace of the fugitive gods, stay on the god's tracks, and so trace for their kindred mortals the way toward the turning" [1, pg.94]. Poets then are those, visited by the wine god, who can observe in some way the fugitive gods. If poets can observe traces of the fugitive gods, then they can also observe the way towards the turning point.

Poets can trace the fugitive gods by tracking the holy. If “the holy is the track of the fugitive god”, then the “poet in the time of the world’s night utters the holy” [1, pg.94]. In order for the poet to utter the holy, they must make their life work about the nature of poetry. In doing so, the poet can trace the holy as far as its own path allows. Now how far does the poet have to reach to find the holy?

During a destitute time, the holy is close to unrecognizable. This is because “it lacks the unconcealedness of the nature of pain, death, and love” which means “this destitution is itself destitute because the realm of being withdraws within which pain and death and love belong” [1, pg.97]. In other words, lack of observing the nature of pain, death, and love causes the holy to be concealed. Therefore, if we want to trace the holy, then we must reveal the nature of pain, death, and love.

Before we can find the nature of pain, death, and love, we need to know what Heidegger means by nature. For him, Nature is the “Being of beings” and “the being of beings is the will” [1, pg.101]. Essentially meaning that every being (like a human or animal) has a way of being/existing and this is driven by their will. Therefore, in order to understand the nature of pain, death, and love, we need to understand their wills. This can be done when being enters the Open.

The Open is the boundless and to be boundless is freedom from restriction. Heidegger believed the Open to be “the whole of the unbound drawings of the whole draft, as well as openness in the sense of a universally prevailing release from all bounds” [1, pg.107]. In other words, the Open is the space of everything not living. If one is not bound to anything it still exists, it just doesn’t live. If this is the case, then how are poets able to enter the Open?

Poets enter the Open because the Open admits them. If being is admitted into the Open, then being is “to draw in and to fit into the unlightened whole of the drawings of the pure draft” [1, pg.107]. Meaning that to enter the Open, being must gravitate towards and become part of the totality of everything objective to Life. Therefore, being must will itself into the space where nothing is willed if we are to find the nature of love, pain, and death.

This is a dangerous adventure for the poet. It is dangerous because “The danger consists in the threat that assault’s man’s nature in his relation to Being itself, and not accidental perils” [1, pg.117]. The danger occurs when being travels into the space where nothing is willed because it can cause being to question its own will. Questioning one’s own will is questioning whether one should be/exist. Alas, the unshieldedness will keep being safe.

The unshieldedness protects Being because it inverts our parting from the Open. For instance, when beings are admitted into the Open, the “Unshieldedness can keep us safe only when the parting from the Open is inverted, so that it turns the Open—and into it.” [1, pg.121]. Beings are safe from the open when unshieldedness is reversed because a conversion occurs.

This conversion is the conversion between consciousness and nonconsciousness. It occurs when “the turning of unshieldedness into the Open concerns the nature of unshieldedness from the very start, this conversion of unshieldedness is a conversion of consciousness, and that inside sphere of consciousness” [1, pg.127]. This inside sphere of consciousness is the innermost of the inner of the being. In other, it is a conversion of the heart’s being revealed.

This conversion is important because it reveals the being of the heart. This being of the heart

is a “transmutation of what is visible in representation into that which is visible of the heart” [1, pg.134]. Once the heart is revealed, we can see the nature of love, pain and death. Because we can see the nature of love, pain, and death, we can now see the holy.

Heidegger believes poets are the ones who can reveal the holy during destitute times. To reveal the holy, the poet must travel into the open where everything with no will lives. The poet must navigate its way through this until it can reverse the unshieldedness of the Open. Once this is achieved, the holy is revealed and consciousness restored.

Lastly, Heidegger’s reading is coherent if you read it with intense concentration. This is because he uses specific well-defined terminology tied to other specific well-defined terminology. To truly understand what Heidegger is saying, you will have to spend a lot of time understanding what his terminology means and how it ties everything together. Because you have to do this to understand him, I find his writing unconvincing.

References

- [1] M. Heidegger and A. Hofstadter. *Poetry, Language, Thought*. Colophon books. Harper & Row, 1975.